

IANS

LOOKING AHEAD

As of now, the roaches want to stay apolitical and let the people set agenda

WIDENING WEB: A movement born on Instagram is going to towns and villages, widening the battle into a campaign about education, jobs and state accountability

FOLLOWERS ARE NOT CADRE: Which is why it is putting together national structures covering policy, legal affairs, finance, technology, media and administration

THE PUBLIC MATTERS: CJP is asking people about their grievances. The 'Kya Bolti Public?' campaign raised issues such as recruitment irregularities and social security for gig workers

SOCIAL MEDIA: It's the CJP's 'Brahmastra'. The 'School Thik Karo' campaign offers a glimpse of how the weapon works

"To bring accountability in judiciary, politics, media and the Election Commission, the CJP will be a pressure group for now"

— ABHIJEET DIPKE, *Founder & Convenor, CJP*

decades-old duopoly of the DMK-AIADMK (Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam-All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam). Yet, nationally, Gen Z presence in the corridors of power remains minuscule: there are just six MPs who are less than 30 years old in the 543-strong Lok Sabha and only 20 among the country's 4,131 MLAs.

Dipke is wise to be cautious. India's post-Independence history is littered with agitations that shook governments, only to fade away. A few, however, did alter the political landscape fundamentally (see box, *Youth in Revolt*). Like the 1974 *Sampoorna Kranti* or Total Revolution movement in Bihar, the student uprising that, under the moral authority of Gandhian leader Jayaprakash Narayan, led to the crushing defeat of Indira Gandhi in the 1977 Lok Sabha election. In the 1990s, the anti-reservation agitation permanently reordered the politics of caste and representation, giving India leaders such as Lalu Prasad Yadav and Nitish Kumar in Bihar and Mulayam Singh Yadav in Uttar Pradesh. More recently, the 2011 India Against Corruption (IAC) movement erupted with the demand for a Lokpal, a national statutory ombudsman body, to investigate graft charges against public functionaries, including the prime minister. It saw Gandhian activist Anna Hazare go on a hunger strike until the Manmohan Singh government relented to the demand. That movement gave birth to Arvind Kejriwal's Aam Aadmi Party (AAP), which ruled Delhi for over 10 years until 2025 and expanded its sweep to Punjab in 2022.

SOMETHING CHANGED AT JANTAR MANTAR. THE FEAR OF OFFICIALDOM DISAPPEARED. "NOW, THEY ARE AFRAID OF US," SAYS CJP'S DEEPAK BALIYAN

The CJP may not be looking that far right now, but, in NEET's failure, it found a grievance that was simultaneously specific and universal. Competitive examinations remain one of the few routes to financial security and upward mobility available to lower- and middle-income households in the country. Years of study, coaching fees and family savings are invested in the hope that, however brutal the competition, their children will get a fair opportunity. It was this faith that the rigged NEET examination destroyed yet again, and it was the pent-up angst and anger that erupted this summer at Jantar Mantar.

"The CJP was not talking caste, community or religion, but was focused exclusively on examinations and on the issues of fairness and equity, which resonated well," says Congress general secretary Jairam Ramesh, who was among those behind Rahul Gandhi's Bharat Jodo Yatra in 2022-23. According to him, the CJP's strength lies in its ability to caricature political figures, including the prime minister himself: "There